Student Activity

Cell lab: students prepare the slide and identify the different types tissues.

Xylem Consists of Four Types of Cells

1. Tracheids
2. Vessels or Trachea
3. Xylem Parenchyma
4. Xylem Fibres

Tracheids

Tracheids are dead, lignified and elongated cells with tapering ends. Its lumen is broader than that of fibres. In cross section, the tracheids are polygonal.

There are different types of cell wall thickenings due to the deposition of secondary wall substances. They are annular (ring like), spiral (spring like), scalariform (ladder like) reticulate (net like) and pitted (uniformly thick except at pits). Tracheids are imperforated cells with bordered pits on their side walls. Only through this conduction takes place in Gymnosperms. They are arranged one above the other. Tracheids are chief water conducting elements in Gymnosperms and Pteridophytes. They also offer mechanical support to the plants.

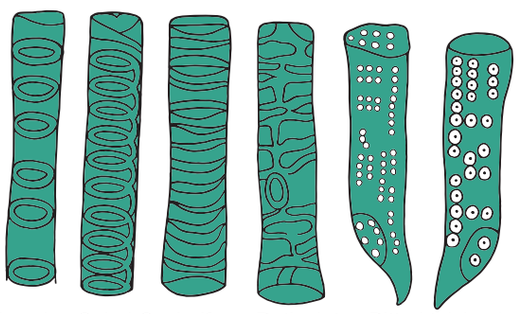


Figure 9.10: Types of secondary wall thickenings in tracheids and vessels

Vessels or Trachea

Vessels are elongated tube like structure. They are dead cells formed from a row of vessel elements placed end to end. They are perforated at the end walls. Their lumen is wider than Tracheids. Due to the dissolution of entire cell wall, a single pore is formed at the perforation plate. It is called **simple perforation plate**, Example: *Mangifera*. If the perforation plate has many pores, it is called **multiple perforation plate**. Example *Liriodendron.*

The secondary wall thickening of vessels are annular, spiral, scalariform, reticulate, or pitted as in tracheids, Vessels are chief water conducting elements in Angiosperms and absent in Pteridophytes and Gymnosperms. In G*netum* of Gymnosperm, vessels occur. The main function is conduction of water, minerals and also offers mechanical strength.

Xylem Fibre

The fibres of sclerenchyma associated with the xylem are known as xylem fibres. Xylem fibres are dead cells and have lignified walls with narrow lumen. They cannot conduct water but being stronger provide mechanical strength. They are present in both primary and secondary xylem. Xylem fibres are also called libriform fibres.

The fibres are abundantly found in many plants. They occur in patches, in continuous bands and sometimes singly among other cells. Between fibres and normal tracheids, there are many transitional forms which are neither typical fibres nor typical tracheids. The transitional types are designated as **fibre-tracheids**. The pits of fibre-tracheids are smaller than those of vessels and typical tracheids.



Vessels are found in Gymnosperms like *Ephedra, Gnetum* and *Welwitschia*

Vesselless angiospermic families *Winteraceae, Tetracentraceae* and *Trochodendracae.*

Xylem Parenchyma

The parenchyma cells associated with the xylem are known as xylem parenchyma. These are the only living cells in xylem tissue. The cell wall is thin and made up of cellulose. Parenchyma arranged longitudinally along the long axis is called **axial parenchyma**.

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